

Half a Million Dollars, A Hundred Billion in Damage

Lesson 36 — Al-Qaeda, 9/11, and their regional impact

What you will know and be able to do

- 1 Trace Al-Qaeda's origins from the Soviet-Afghan War to a distinct organisation
- 2 Explain bin Laden's specific grievance against Saudi Arabia and the United States
- 3 Describe how Al-Qaeda's structure adapted after losing its Afghan safe haven
- 4 Evaluate the direct link between the 2003 Iraq War and Al-Qaeda's most consequential offshoot

Stepping back to the movement behind the war

Lesson 35 covered the 2003 Iraq War, launched partly in response to September 11. This lesson steps back to examine the organisation behind that attack — and then forward again, to how the war's own chaos helped create Al-Qaeda's most dangerous successor.

The Soviet-Afghan War, 1979–89

Osama bin Laden, son of a wealthy Saudi construction magnate, began providing money, weapons, and logistics to Afghan mujahideen fighting Soviet occupation from the early 1980s. In 1984, he partnered with Palestinian-Jordanian theologian Abdullah Azzam — later called the intellectual father of modern jihadism — to found the Maktab al-Khidamat in Peshawar, Pakistan, recruiting and funding thousands of foreign Arab volunteers.

11 August 1988: ‘the Base’

As Soviet withdrawal approached, bin Laden wanted to redirect this trained, battle-hardened network toward a broader struggle. Al-Qaeda — Arabic for “the Base” — originally referred simply to the record-keeping system tracking mujahideen fighters and resources at the training camps; the name stuck as the organisation itself took shape.

American troops on Saudi soil

Bin Laden's opposition to Saudi Arabia's decision to host US troops during the 1990–91 Gulf War became a defining, deeply personal grievance — in his view, a desecration of the land holding Islam's two holiest sites. This specific episode redirected his movement's focus from foreign occupiers generally toward the United States, and toward his own government, directly.

The 1996 and 1998 fatwas

Based in Sudan and later Afghanistan under Taliban protection after his 1996 expulsion, bin Laden issued a formal declaration of war against American forces in the Arabian Peninsula that same year, followed by a broader 1998 fatwa, alongside Egyptian Islamic Jihad's Ayman al-Zawahiri, calling for jihad against “Jews and Crusaders” more widely.

Embassies, a warship, then the World Trade Center

On 7 August 1998, coordinated bombings devastated US embassies in Nairobi and Dar es Salaam, killing over 220 people; the October 2000 USS Cole bombing in Yemen killed 17 American sailors. These attacks, though deadly, were a prelude to what followed on 11 September 2001.

September 11, 2001, by the numbers

~3,000

People killed, including the 19 hijackers themselves

<\$500,000

Estimated total cost to Al-Qaeda of planning and executing the attacks

~\$100 billion

Estimated property damage alone

This gap between cost and consequence became a defining feature of the asymmetric warfare Al-Qaeda pioneered.

Operation Enduring Freedom

The United States launched its invasion of Afghanistan on 7 October 2001, toppling the Taliban government that had sheltered bin Laden within weeks — though the wider war continued for two more decades, and bin Laden himself escaped capture entirely at this stage.

From centralised leadership to ‘franchising’

Losing its secure Afghan base did not destroy Al-Qaeda — it forced structural evolution. Increasingly autonomous regional affiliates, sharing the Al-Qaeda name and broader ideology but operating with real independence, meant the organisation was linked to more attacks in the six years after 2001 than in the six years before it.

Was 'Al-Qaeda' ever really one organisation?

Former CIA officer and terrorism analyst Marc Sageman has argued there was never a single, tightly organised entity in the way popular imagination assumed — describing Al-Qaeda instead as a loose, decentralised network that convenient shorthand treats as more unified than the reality actually was. This scepticism matters directly for how confidently any essay can generalise about “Al-Qaeda’s” decisions as a single actor's choices.

Al-Qaeda in Iraq, born from a war Al-Qaeda didn't start

The chaos and sectarian violence following the 2003 Iraq War, covered in Lesson 35, created ideal conditions for a new, especially brutal affiliate: Al-Qaeda in Iraq. This is a direct, traceable link — the American-led war against Saddam Hussein, justified partly by claimed Iraqi terrorist ties that did not actually exist beforehand, helped generate the terrorist presence Iraq previously lacked.

From AQI to the Islamic State

AQI renamed itself the Islamic State of Iraq in 2006, and expanded into Syria as that country's own civil war erupted from 2011. Its extreme brutality, including mass public executions, eventually alarmed even Al-Qaeda's central leadership — leading to a formal, hostile split, after which the group became fully independent as ISIS, a rival to Al-Qaeda rather than an ally.

2 May 2011, Abbottabad

US Navy SEALs killed Osama bin Laden in a covert raid on his compound in Abbottabad, Pakistan — not, notably, in Afghanistan's remote tribal areas, but in a garrison town uncomfortably close to Pakistan's own military academy, raising lasting questions about what Pakistani authorities may have known.

Zawahiri, and a decade more of pursuit

Ayman al-Zawahiri succeeded bin Laden as Al-Qaeda's leader, continuing to direct the organisation's ideological messaging for over a decade before being killed by a US drone strike in Kabul in July 2022 — a reminder that removing a founder, even a symbolically central one, does not necessarily end the organisation or the broader ideological current it represents.

A full essay attempt

'The 2003 Iraq War did more to strengthen Sunni jihadist terrorism in the Middle East than any action taken by Al-Qaeda itself.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence: AQI's emergence, its evolution into ISIS, and Al-Qaeda's own attacks
- Address the counter-argument that Al-Qaeda's ideology and 9/11 itself were the more fundamental cause

Key terms from today

Maktab al-Khidamat

The Afghan Services Bureau, Al-Qaeda's organisational precursor.

Al-Qaeda in Iraq

The affiliate born directly from post-2003 Iraqi instability.

Franchising

Al-Qaeda's post-2001 shift to semi-autonomous regional affiliates.

Asymmetric warfare

Achieving disproportionate impact relative to the resources actually spent.

What to remember

Al-Qaeda grew from the Soviet-Afghan War into a organisation defined by bin Laden's specific grievance over American troops in Saudi Arabia, adapting into a decentralised network of affiliates once it lost its secure Afghan base. Its most consequential legacy may be indirect: the 2003 Iraq War's chaos directly enabled Al-Qaeda in Iraq's rise, and that group's later, hostile split produced ISIS — the subject of our next lesson.

Lesson 37 — Closing Block B6: essay practice

Next lesson closes this block with focused essay practice across peace processes, political Islam, and 2003's aftermath, before Block B7 turns to the Arab Spring and the region's most recent transformations.